

Essay 2 Homework

My sources

Gloria Anzaldúa, How to Tame a Wild Tongue.

Albert Camus, The Myth of Sisyphus, Absurdism unit.

Critics spend large amounts of energy looking for faults in others' work that could better be spent building on it. Deborah Tannen, "Agonism in Academic Discourse," p. 1661.

We might imagine it's the job of an academic essayist to stage a debate with sides and a winner and a loser. A more accurate model for scholarly argument is conversation. In intellectual conversation, the goal is not to defeat the opposition but to advance the shared understanding of a community of readers. The author's own contribution matters. If the writer is not present as a participant and mediator, the essay becomes a report of what others have said. The goal of an essay is to build on others' ideas to produce new knowledge.

Revise your paragraph to better employ They Say, I Say strategies:

Deborah Tannen argues that critics waste energy finding faults instead of building on ideas. I agree in part, and I extend her point to academic writing. The job isn't to score a win. The job is to move a live conversation forward for your readers.

Some assume an essay must set up two sides and declare a winner. That frame narrows inquiry. Academic writing works as conversation among sources and you. You

name what others claim. You enter with a clear position. You explain where you agree, where you differ, and why it matters.

If me, the writer, don't show up on the page, the piece turns into summary. Readers lose the thread. My task is to build on others' strongest ideas. I add a specific claim, tied to close reading or data. I show what my move changes for how we read the exhibit.